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U.S. Economics News:

- **Sector Performance Divergence:** Real Estate Services saw the sharpest earnings downgrades among 2026's worst performers, with analyst estimates for 2026-2027 declining 15.8% and 14.0% respectively since year-end. Meanwhile, software subsectors defied their weak stock performance with modest earnings upgrades — Application and Systems Software saw 2026 estimates rise 2.5% and 1.8%, suggesting market pessimism may be overdone for technology sectors.[3]
- **Fed Paralysis Deepens:** The FOMC held rates at 3.5-3.75% as Powell admitted members have "no conviction" on the economic outlook amid Iran conflict uncertainty. Markets now price zero 2026 rate cuts versus two expected in December, with year-end fed funds projections jumping from 3.05% to 3.72%. The Fed raised 2026 inflation forecasts to 2.7% from 2.4% while maintaining unemployment and slightly upgrading GDP growth expectations.[3]
- **Inflation Surprises Services-Led:** February PPI surged 0.7% versus 0.3% expected, driven unexpectedly by services inflation rising at an 8.1% annualized three-month rate while goods prices increased just 2.5% annually. Core services excluding trade and transportation rose 0.6% monthly but only 3.4% annualized over three months, suggesting underlying inflation remains moderate despite headline volatility from Supreme Court tariff rulings and Iran-related disruptions.[3]
- **Housing Market Freeze:** New single-family home sales plummeted 17.6% in January to 587,000 annualized, the largest monthly decline since 2013, likely due to severe winter storms rather than fundamental weakness. The 30-year mortgage rate jumped 20 basis points to 6.3% following Iran conflict escalation, while months' supply climbed to 9.7 as completed homes inventory reached 2009 highs, pressuring median prices down 6.8% year-over-year.[3]
- **Money Supply Divergence:** M2 growth of 4.3% year-over-year remains below the pre-COVID 6% trend that historically accompanied 2% inflation, suggesting monetary policy is appropriately tight despite producer price increases. This contradicts Fed speculation about potential rate hikes, as goods inflation of 2.5% versus services inflation of 3.8% indicates tariff impacts remain muted while pandemic-era "supercore" services inflation persists despite Powell dismissing concerns.[3]

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Digital Assets News:

- **Four Categories:** SEC guidance outlined a classification framework dividing digital assets into four distinct categories — digital commodities (like Bitcoin), collectibles (NFTs and unique tokens), utility tools (functional application tokens), stablecoins (price-stable digital currencies), and securities (investment contracts subject to federal securities laws) — providing regulatory clarity for market participants navigating compliance obligations.[5]
- **Family Offices:** Nearly a quarter of limited partners on the iConnections platform have expressed active interest in digital asset investment strategies, signaling growing institutional appetite despite regulatory uncertainty. This trend reflects family offices' increasing willingness to allocate capital toward cryptocurrency, blockchain infrastructure, and tokenized assets as they seek diversification and exposure to emerging technologies that could reshape traditional financial markets.[5]
- **Quantum Security:** The Ethereum Foundation significantly accelerated its post-quantum cryptography initiatives in response to emerging quantum computing threats, with particular emphasis on LeanVM — a lean virtual machine implementation designed to integrate quantum-resistant cryptographic primitives. These efforts aim to future-proof Ethereum's infrastructure against potential vulnerabilities that sufficiently powerful quantum computers could exploit, ensuring long-term network security and asset protection as quantum technology advances.[5]
- **Gold Ratio:** Bitcoin is positioning for its first positive monthly candle against gold in eight months, signaling a potential shift in relative strength between the two store-of-value assets. This reversal comes after gold's extended outperformance throughout late 2024, suggesting renewed institutional appetite for digital assets and a possible rotation of capital back into cryptocurrency markets as risk sentiment improves.[5]

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Geopolitics News:

- **European Union:** EU foreign policy chief Kaja Kallas stated diplomatic solutions needed for Strait of Hormuz as nobody willing to risk troops; EU offered to fund Ukrainian pipeline repairs to resolve Hungary's veto of 90-billion-euro Ukraine loan.[1]
- **Iran:** Israeli attacks on Iran's Pars gas field marked first strikes on Gulf energy infrastructure; Iran retaliated by targeting Qatar's largest gas plant, Saudi refinery, UAE facilities and Kuwaiti refineries, causing extensive damage.[1]
- **Iran:** Iran's new supreme leader Ayatollah Mojtaba Khamenei rejected de-escalation offers conveyed by intermediaries, demanding US and Israel be "brought to their knees" before considering peace talks with compensation requirements.[1]
- **Iran:** About 90 ships including oil tankers crossed Strait of Hormuz despite effective closure, with Iran exporting over 16 million barrels of oil since war started primarily to China through "dark" transits evading sanctions.[1]
- **Iran:** Iran war triggered helium shortage affecting semiconductor supply chains globally; semiconductor-grade helium essential for chipmaking with no alternatives, threatening to slow or halt fabrication without contamination-free ultra-high-purity helium.[1]
- **Lebanon:** Lebanese President Joseph Aoun proposed first direct Israel talks in decades following heavy bombardment killing 850 Lebanese and displacing over one million; Lebanon wants fighting to end before negotiations begin.[1]
- **Russia:** Kremlin announced Ukraine peace talks on "situational pause" due to Iran war; spokesman Dmitry Peskov said talks would resume when American partners could pay more attention to Ukrainian affairs.[1]
- **United States:** Pentagon requested $200 billion in additional Iran war funding requiring Congressional approval; Defense Secretary Pete Hegseth stated "it takes money to kill bad guys" without confirming exact amount.[1]
- **United States:** Trump administration eased Venezuela oil sanctions allowing PDVSA to sell directly to US companies and global markets while waiving Jones Act requirements for 60 days to boost oil supplies during Iran war.[1]

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The Good News:

- **Space Mirrors:** California startup Reflect Orbital has applied for FCC approval to launch a prototype satellite with a 60-foot mirror this summer, pioneering technology to bounce sunlight to Earth's night side. The company's vision includes deploying 50,000 orbital mirrors to extend solar farm operations after sunset, illuminate rescue operations, and light city streets — bringing renewable energy generation into nighttime hours.[2]
- **Bridge Safety:** Satellite radar imaging now detects millimeter-scale structural movements in bridges worldwide, identifying potential problems before human inspectors can spot them. This technology is particularly transformative for aging North American infrastructure and regions lacking traditional monitoring systems, potentially reducing the number of bridges classified as high-risk through early intervention and preventive maintenance.[2]
- **Affordable Ozempic:** Novo Nordisk's patent on semaglutide (Ozempic/Wegovy) expires Saturday in countries representing 40% of global population, with generic versions launching immediately in India and soon in China, Canada, Brazil, Turkey, and South Africa. Analysts project prices could eventually drop to $15 monthly as competition increases, making this transformative weight-loss medication accessible to billions previously priced out of treatment.[2]
- **Child Survival:** Global under-five mortality has plunged 60% since 1990, while neonatal deaths fell 45%, saving millions of lives through expanded immunization, essential health services, newborn care, and nutrition support. Though progress continues in sub-Saharan Africa and Southern Asia, the dramatic three-decade improvement demonstrates how sustained investment in childhood health interventions delivers measurable results.[2]

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Dividend Portfolio News:

- **GD:** General Dynamics subsidiary secured a $15.38 billion U.S. Navy modification contract. Defense stocks have underperformed market expectations despite escalating Iran conflict, according to WSJ analysis.[4]
- **GPC:** Genuine Parts Company appeared on lists of most oversold stocks in both the S&P 500 and large-cap universe, suggesting potential value opportunity after recent market weakness.[4]
- **NEE:** NextEra Energy selected to build $17 billion Pennsylvania power plant unveiled by Trump administration. Nvidia and Emerald partnered with power firms on AI factories and grid infrastructure, potentially benefiting NextEra's renewable energy capabilities.[4]
- **QCOM:** Qualcomm authorized $20 billion stock buyback and raised dividend. Named top pick by analysts, but Citi flagged negative ROE trends. Shareholders rejected China-risk proposal. Chip sales topped $830 billion in 2025 driven by AI growth. Sector volatility from Iran war and correction concerns.[4]
- **STLD:** Steel Dynamics issued Q1 earnings guidance below consensus expectations, signaling near-term headwinds for the steel producer and metals recycler.[4]

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Growth Portfolio News

- **AMD:** In talks to sell 10,000 AI chips to Korea's Upstage; partnering with Samsung on AI memory and exploring foundry collaboration. Chip sales sector-wide topped $830B in 2025 with AMD among leaders in AI-driven growth.[4]
- **ATAT:** Q4 GAAP EPS of $0.48 beat estimates by $0.04, but revenue of $399M missed by $7.83M.[4]
- **FINV:** Q4 non-GAAP EPS $0.25, revenue $432.4M; earnings and revenue fell less than expected. Raised dividend 10.5% to $0.306. Targets 50% international revenue by 2030 as overseas growth accelerates.[4]
- **GFI:** Gold broke down with RSI flashing extreme oversold, sliding 5% and breaking key 100-day MA as safe-haven demand faded. Ghana assessing bids for $1B revival of Damang mine previously seized from Gold Fields.[4]
- **NVDA:** Announced $1T backlog, partnered with Emerald and power firms on AI factories, secured AWS deal to sell 1M AI chips by end of 2027. OpenClaw integration marks shift beyond hardware; received China's approval to sell H200 chips and preparing Groq chips for Chinese market. Multiple partnerships including Coupang, Roche, STMicroelectronics, Hesai, and AEye for AI solutions. Musk confirmed SpaceX and Tesla will keep buying chips at scale.[4]

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Summary:

In regard to the United States Economy, the Federal Reserve held rates steady at 3.5-3.75% as Chair Powell acknowledged deep uncertainty about the economic outlook. Markets now expect zero rate cuts this year, a dramatic shift from December's projections. February producer prices jumped unexpectedly, driven by services inflation accelerating while goods prices remained moderate. Housing markets showed stress as new home sales plunged 17.6% and mortgage rates climbed following geopolitical tensions.

In the world of digital assets, regulatory clarity emerged as the SEC outlined a four-category classification framework distinguishing commodities, collectibles, utility tokens, stablecoins, and securities. Institutional interest continued growing with nearly a quarter of family offices expressing active allocation interest. Ethereum accelerated its quantum-resistant cryptography initiatives to safeguard against emerging computational threats. Bitcoin showed signs of reversing its prolonged underperformance against gold, potentially signaling renewed institutional appetite for digital assets.

Recently around the globe, Iran's conflict escalated dramatically after Israeli strikes on energy infrastructure prompted retaliatory attacks across Gulf facilities in Qatar, Saudi Arabia, and the UAE. Iran's new supreme leader rejected de-escalation offers, demanding the United States and Israel be "brought to their knees" before negotiations. The Pentagon requested $200 billion in additional funding while Russia paused Ukraine peace talks. The crisis triggered semiconductor supply chain concerns due to helium shortages.

For the good news, California startup Reflect Orbital applied for approval to launch orbital mirrors that could extend solar energy generation into nighttime hours. Satellite radar imaging now detects millimeter-scale bridge movements worldwide, enabling early structural problem identification. Novo Nordisk's semaglutide patent expires this week in countries representing 40% of global population, with prices potentially dropping to $15 monthly. Global childhood mortality has plunged 60% since 1990, saving millions through expanded health services.

In the news for the dividend portfolio, General Dynamics secured a $15.38 billion Navy contract modification despite defense stocks underperforming during Iran tensions. Genuine Parts appeared on oversold stock lists, suggesting potential value opportunities. NextEra Energy was selected to build a $17 billion Pennsylvania power plant and benefits from partnerships expanding AI infrastructure. Qualcomm authorized $20 billion in buybacks and raised dividends while chip sales topped $830 billion.

And, for the growth portfolio, AMD entered discussions to sell AI chips to Korea's Upstage while partnering with Samsung on AI memory solutions. FinVolution raised its dividend 10.5% and targets 50% international revenue by 2030. Gold Fields faced pressure as gold prices broke technical support levels. Nvidia announced a $1 trillion backlog, secured AWS commitments for one million AI chips by 2027, and expanded partnerships across multiple industries.

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